

Ubiquity Of Christs Body

doc-ubiquity-of-christs-body

Sacraments · Lord's Supper · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Christ's glorified human body is ubiquitous (omnipresent) by virtue of its union with the divine nature.

In plain language

The words of these passages describe Christ's body in spatial, bounded terms. In Acts 1 a cloud lifts him up (the Greek 'was lifted up', epērhē) and takes him away from the disciples' eyes (the Greek 'from', apo), and the angels say this same Jesus (the Greek 'this one', houtos), taken into heaven (the Greek 'into the heaven', eis ton ouranon), will come back (the Greek 'he will come', eleusetai) the same way they saw him go. The Greek marks one identifiable person, one destination named as heaven, and a future bodily return, the language of a body that moves from place to place and is for now in one place. A whole chain of texts then locates that body at one position: he sat down (the Greek 'he sat down', ekathisen) at the right hand (the Greek 'at the right', en dexia), where Stephen sees him standing (the Greek 'standing', hestōta), and the right-hand phrase recurs again and again across the writings. Luke 24 has the risen Jesus invite the disciples to touch him, since a spirit does not have flesh and bones (the Greek 'flesh and bones', sarka kai ostea) as they see him having, so the resurrection body is tangible and occupies definite space. Paul says the supper is kept until he comes (the Greek 'until which he should come', achri hou elthē), which implies the Lord is not yet present bodily in the full way he will be at that coming. The proposition, though, is not just a claim about where the body is. It claims the body (the Greek 'body', sōma) is everywhere at once because of its union with the divine nature. That is a reasoned conclusion about how the two natures share properties, and the plain vocabulary of these verses does not state it. The one verse that comes closest, that he ascended to fill all things (the verb 'to fill', plēroō), has the ascended person as its subject and uses a verb that elsewhere means fill in a non-spatial way, so it can be read either as the whole Christ filling all things or simply as the divine person doing so. One reading attributes the divine quality of being everywhere to the human body through the union; another keeps the body finite and located while the divine person stays unbounded. Because the surface words consistently point to a located, touchable, awaited body, while the metaphysical claim sits above the level the words themselves settle, the lexical verdict is disputed rather than a clean yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0353	ἀναλαμβάνω	analambano	to take up	13
G0575	ἀπό	apo	away from	675
G0891	ἄχρι	achri	until	50
G1188	δεξιός	dexios	right	54
G1209	δέχομαι	dechomai	to receive	
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	

G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	1,793
G1869	ἐπαίρω	epairo	to lift up	19
G2064	ἔρχομαι	erchomai	to come/go	640
G2476	ἵστημι	histemi	to stand	153
G2521	κάθημαι	kathēmai	to sit	
G2523	καθίζω	kathizo	to seat	45
G3747	ὀστέον	osteon	bone	5
G3772	οὐρανός	ouranos	heaven	280
G3778	οὗτος	houtos	this/he/she/it	1,419
G4137	πληρώω	pleroo	to fulfill	87
G4561	σὰρξ	sarx	flesh	151
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5602	ἔδε	hōde	here	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across the whole Bible, the vocabulary that describes the risen and ascended body is uniformly spatial and locative (about place and direction). In Acts 1:9-11 a cloud lifts Jesus up (the Greek 'was lifted up', epērthē, G1869) and removes him from the disciples' eyes (the Greek 'from the eyes', apo tōn ophthalmōn, G0575), this same one (the Greek demonstrative 'this one', houtos, G3778) is taken up (the Greek 'having been taken up', analēmphtheis, G0353) into heaven (the Greek 'into the heaven', eis ton ouranon, G3772, naming a single destination), and will come (the Greek future 'he will come', eleusetai, G2064) in the same manner. A dense chain spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical) then locates the body at one place: he sat down (the Greek 'he sat down', ekathisen, G2523) at the right hand (the Greek 'at the right', en dexia, G1188, 54 occurrences clustered at Acts 2:33, 7:55-56, Romans 8:34, Ephesians 1:20, Colossians 3:1, Hebrews 1:3, 10:12, 1 Peter 3:22), where Stephen sees him standing (the Greek 'standing', hestōta, G2476). Luke 24:39 offers a touchable body of flesh and bones (the Greek 'flesh and bones', sarka kai ostea, G4561, G3747), and 1 Corinthians 11:26 bounds the supper until he comes (the Greek 'until which he should come', achri hou elthē, G0891). These words describe a circumscribed (bounded in space), locatable body and never predicate (assert as a property of) omnipresence (being present everywhere) of it. The proposition, however, is not a claim the lexemes (the dictionary-form words themselves) make: it is an inference about how the divine nature shares properties with the human nature, sitting one level above what the morphology (word-form analysis) of these verses settles, so the verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Acts.1.9 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1869 ἐπαίρω, G0575 ἀπό

Reasoning. A cloud lifts Jesus up (the Greek 'was lifted up', epērthē, G1869) and takes him away from their eyes (the Greek 'took him up from their eyes', hypelaben auton apo tōn ophthalmōn autōn). The verb of being lifted plus the Greek preposition 'from' (apo) with the genitive (the 'from-X' grammatical form) of the disciples' eyes marks a single body departing from one location, the language of removal from a place, not of a body becoming present everywhere. The same Greek verb 'to lift up' (epairō) is used a few verses earlier at Luke 24:50 for lifting the hands, a concrete physical motion.

Acts.1.11 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0353 ἀναλαμβάνω, G3772 οὐρανός, G3778 οὗτος, G2064 ἔρχομαι

Reasoning. This same Jesus (the Greek 'this Jesus', houtos ho lēsous), having been taken up (the Greek 'having been taken up', analēphtheis, G0353) from you into heaven (the Greek 'into the heaven', eis ton ouranon), will so come (the Greek 'thus he will come', houtōs eleusetai, G2064) in the manner you saw him going. The demonstrative 'this one' (houtos) fixes one personal identity, the phrase 'into the heaven' (eis ton ouranon) names one destination, and the future middle 'he will come' (eleusetai) with the comparative 'thus' (houtōs) describes a bodily return from that place. The verb 'to take up' (anambanō) carries a stable directional sense across its 13 occurrences (Acts 1:2, 1:22, Mark 16:19, 1 Timothy 3:16), all of taking up or away.

Acts.7.55 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1188 δεξιός, G2476 ἵστημι

Reasoning. Stephen gazes into heaven and sees Jesus standing (the Greek 'standing', hestōta, G2476) at the right hand of God (the Greek 'from the right [hand parts] of God', ek dexiōn tou theou, G1188). A located posture (standing) at a named position (the right hand) is the plain force. The right-hand idiom recurs across the canon for the exalted Christ (Acts 2:33, Romans 8:34, Ephesians 1:20, Colossians 3:1, Hebrews 1:3, 1 Peter 3:22), a pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) pattern placing the body at one position rather than diffused through all space.

Luke.24.39 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4561 σὰρξ, G3747 ὀστέον

Reasoning. See my hands and feet, that it is I myself; handle me and see, for a spirit does not have flesh and bones (the Greek 'flesh and bones', sarka kai ostea, G4561, G3747) as you see me having. The risen body is offered as touchable, occupying definite space, and is explicitly contrasted with a bodiless spirit (the Greek 'spirit', pneuma), a description of a bounded physical body. The Greek word for 'bone' (osteon) is rare (5 occurrences) and here grounds the concrete corporeality (physical body-ness) of the resurrection body.

John.6.63 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4561 σὰρξ, G1510 εἰμί

Reasoning. The Spirit is the life-giver, the flesh profits nothing (the Greek 'the flesh profits nothing', hē sarx ouk ōphelai ouden); the words I have spoken are spirit and are life. The contrast set between 'flesh' (sarx) and 'spirit' (pneuma) warns against a crassly fleshly hearing and concerns the mode of receiving Christ's words, not the spatial extension of the glorified body. It neither asserts nor denies that the body is everywhere, so it is neutral on the proposition.

1Cor.11.24 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3778 οὗτος, G4983 σῶμα, G1510 εἰμί

Reasoning. This is my body which is for you (the Greek 'this is my body the [one] for you', touto mou estin to sōma to hyper hymōn, G3778, G4983, G1510); do this in remembrance of me. The copula (the linking verb 'is', estin) links the demonstrative 'this' (touto) to 'body' (sōma), and the referent of 'this' (touto, whether the bread held, or the body it signifies) is grammatically open. The remembrance command (the Greek 'into my remembrance', eis tēn emēn anamnēsin) frames the act commemoratively, but the clause specifies neither the mode nor the location of the body, so it neither establishes nor refutes ubiquity (being present everywhere). This ambiguous copula (linking verb 'is') is the syntactic crux the whole dispute hangs on.

1Cor.11.26 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0891 ἄχρι, G2064 ἔρχομαι

Reasoning. As often as you eat this bread and drink the cup you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes (the Greek 'until which he should come', achri hou elthē, G0891, G2064). The temporal 'until' (achri) with the aorist (a completed past action) subjunctive 'he should come' (elthē) bounds the rite by a future coming, implying the Lord is not yet bodily present in the way he will be at that coming. The same 'until' (achri) frames 1 Corinthians 15:25, he must reign until (achri) he has put all enemies under his feet, a bounded interval, reinforcing the absence-then-coming structure.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.1.11	Dan.7.13	tsk	1
Acts.1.9	Acts.1.2	tsk	1
Acts.1.9	Exod.19.9	tsk	1
Luke.24.39	Luke.23.46	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Eph.4.10 · addressed

The clause that he ascended far above all the heavens that he might fill all things (the Greek 'so that he might fill all things', hina plērōsē ta panta, the verb 'to fill', plēroō, G4137) is the strongest lexical (word-based) support cited for the proposition. Queried in context, the grammatical subject is the one who descended and ascended (the Greek 'the one having descended' and 'the one having ascended', ho katabas, ho anabas), a personal subject, and the purpose clause 'so that he might fill' (hina plērōsē) predicates filling of that person, not spatial extension of the body (the Greek 'body', sōma). The same verb 'to fill' (plēroō) is used non-spatially across the canon (Ephesians 1:23, 3:19, Colossians 1:9, Romans 15:13), so filling here need not mean bodily presence everywhere. The text supports a claim about the ascended person filling all things but does not lexically force that the human body is omnipresent (present everywhere), which is why it is contested rather than decisive.

Acts.3.21 · addressed

Peter states that heaven must receive him (the Greek 'whom it is necessary that heaven receive', hon dei ouranon men dexasthai, the verb 'to receive', dechomai, G1209) until the times of restoration (the Greek 'until', achri, G0891). The verb 'to receive, contain' (dexasthai) with the impersonal 'it is necessary' (dei) places the ascended body in heaven for a defined interval, reinforcing a localized rather than ubiquitous (everywhere-present) bodily presence and weighing against the proposition.

John.6.63 · addressed

The flesh-profits-nothing saying is sometimes read as detaching the body's life-giving power from its physical location, which could open room for a non-localized presence. The clause is a contrast between fleshly and spiritual reception of Christ's words, not a statement about the spatial extension of the glorified body, so it does not by itself supply lexical (word-based) support for bodily omnipresence (being everywhere).

Concordance traversed

G0353, G1869, G1188, G2523, G2521, G2476, G4561, G3747, G3772, G0575, G0891, G2064, G3778, G1519, G4137, G4983, G1209, G5602

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle (variant_units empty) and not_in_ecm_scope is true: every anchor (Acts 1, Luke 24, John 6, 1 Corinthians 11) lies outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so the apparatus is structurally absent rather than silently empty. The known textual variation at 1 Corinthians 11:24 (whether the Greek 'being broken', klōmenon, stands in the body clause) does not bear on localization versus ubiquity (being present everywhere), so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. communicatio_idiomatum, two_natures_christology

analogia scripturae invoked

communicated_majesty_to_the_human_nature: disputed · On this reading the personal union is so close that genuinely divine properties, including omnipresence (being present everywhere), are truly predicated of (asserted as belonging to) the assumed human nature, so the body can be present wherever the person is. Its strongest lexical (word-based) footing is Ephesians 4:10 (he ascended that he might fill all things, the verb 'to fill', plēroō) read as filling by the whole Christ including the flesh, joined to the union texts where the one person acts. The reading is coherent at the level of dogmatic inference, but the surface lexicon of the cited verses speaks only of a body lifted, seated at one named position, touched, and awaited, and never says the body fills space, so the words underdetermine rather than confirm it.

natures_remain_distinct_body_locatable: false · On this reading the two natures retain their proper attributes within the one person, so the human body stays finite and locatable while the divine person remains unbounded. It rests directly on the plain force of the queried verbs: 'having been taken up into the heaven' (analēmphtheis eis ton ouranon, taken up into one heaven), the pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) right-hand session (the Greek 'at the right', en dexia, sat down, standing), the tangible 'flesh' (sarx) and 'bones' (ostea) of Luke 24:39, and 'until which he should come' (achri hou elthē). These describe a circumscribed (bounded in space) body, so on the words alone the proposition reads as false. Ephesians 4:10 is taken as the person filling all things, with the verb 'to fill' (plēroō) in its frequent non-spatial sense.

The proposition turns on a metaphysical claim about how the natures share properties, a level above what the morphology (word-form analysis) and lexemes (dictionary-form words) of the cited verses adjudicate. The locative verbs and the dense right-hand session chain consistently localize the body, while the one filling text (Ephesians 4:10) is grammatically about the ascended person and uses a verb attested in a non-spatial sense. The competing inferences diverge, which is recorded as cross-tradition divergence.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Question whether Christ's glorified human body is present in more than one place at once, or whether it remains spatially circumscribed (bounded in space) while the divine person is unbounded.

The phrase 'is ubiquitous (omnipresent) by virtue of its union with the divine nature' encodes a specific account of the communication of attributes, embedding one disputed metaphysical conclusion in the stem itself. The neutralized form poses the spatial question without assuming the mechanism. The verdict is derived on the original stem. The prior verdict (disputed, medium) is retained: the deepened query (the right-hand session chain across Acts, Romans, Ephesians, Colossians, Hebrews, 1 Peter, using the Greek 'right' dexios, G1188, and the in-context reading of Ephesians 4:10 with the verb 'to fill', plēroō) confirms rather than overturns it, so affirms is unchanged.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.7.55

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.24.39
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.4.10
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0353
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1188
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4137
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4561
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.3.21
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.1.11

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent